



STEFAAN VUYLSTEKE

Profile

Ghent, Belgium

48 years

+20 years experience

Available

Temporary assignment

Project-based work

Start as of July 2026

Mode

Hybrid Belgium setup

On-site collaboration

Remote for focused work

Contact

+32 484 48 05 24

stefaan@growthup.eu



Explore online

[Relevant projects](#)

[Full career details](#)

Hello Smals team

ready to make digital public services easier to use?

Smals needs a Senior Service Designer who can use Design Thinking methodology to make digital services clearer and easier to use. That fits my profile: I combine customer experience, digital engagement, user research, behavioral insight and service improvement with hands-on concept design. I help teams move from user needs, journeys and service logic towards clearer flows, first wireframes, prototypes and practical input for teams building digital solutions people actually use.

● Design Thinking

Trained teams and embedded Design Thinking in marketing and digital work. Applied the method to digital interfaces, service innovation and service improvement, keeping users central and adding clear validation points with users and stakeholders.

● Digital Touchpoints & Interfaces

Worked on websites, portals, mobile and web apps, SaaS, email and chat-based services. I do not look at one interface in isolation, but at how it fits the wider digital experience and the service people need to use.

● User Research & Journey

I use interviews, surveys, usability tests and behavior mapping to understand what people need, where they get stuck and how a digital service fits their real-life context.

● Beyond Usability

I know usability standards matter, but I also look at context, mental load, trust and emotion, because those often decide whether people actually use a digital self service.

● User Adoption

Experienced in designing adoption of self-service platforms, mobile & web apps beyond onboarding: first use, value moments, return behavior and feature use within people's real-life context.

● Wireframes & Concept Designs

I turn research, journeys and service ideas into flows, wireframes and realistic prototypes. This helps teams discuss, test and refine solutions before design and development work goes too far.

Additional strengths: Human digital design | behavioral science | user testing & optimisation | data-informed UX | content & UX copy | co-creation workshops | stakeholder alignment | +15 years marketing automation | multilingual | data modelling

My career overview

 [Full career details](#)

Start-ups

Roles:

Industries:

2024 Freelance	The Breath Club Mental & emotional health	Senior Service Designer	
2023 Freelance	Miss Mira AI AI-driven elderly companion	Behavioral Research & Design Consultant	
2023 Freelance	Maxis AI AI-driven travel concierge	Behavioral Research & Design Consultant	
2023 Freelance	Beyondr Behavior design	Behavioral Research & Design Consultant	
2022 Freelance	Men IT Digital solutions for mental care	Behavioral Research & Service Consultant	

Agencies

Roles:

Industries:

2025 Freelance	Jems Group (Beobank) Data & UX	UX Research Consultant	
2021 Freelance	Serviceplan Group 360° communication	Digital Engagement Consultant	  
2021 Freelance	Springbok Agency Full digital	Strategy Director Service Design & Digital	  
2016 Employee	Engagement Factory Marketing Automation & CX	Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant	     
2014 Employee	Emakina Group Full digital	CRM & Marketing Automation Team Lead	     
2013 Employee	Serviceplan Group 360° communication	CRM & Marketing Automation Team Lead	    
2012 Employee	J. Walter Thompson Full communication	CRM & Marketing Automation Account Manager	 

Corporates

Roles:

Industries:

2024 Freelance	Proximus Telecom	Business & Service Designer	
2021 Freelance	Arcadis Sustainability solutions	Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant	 
2021 Freelance	SCIA SaaS for civil engineering	Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant	 
2020 Freelance	DPG Media Newspapers & magazines	Customer Experience & Lifecycle Consultant	
2019 Freelance	Telenet Business Telecom & technology	Business & Service Designer	 
2015 Employee	Wolters Kluwer Information & software solutions	Marketing Director	 
2008 Employee	Amadeus Travel technology solutions	Customer Segment Manager & Innovation Manager	  
2006 Employee	TNT Group Courier delivery services	Marketing & Product Manager	 
2005 Employee	Princess Home Small household appliances	Retail Marketing Manager	
2003 Employee	Blending International Enterprise software	Customer Segment & CRM Manager	

[Full career details →](#)

Understanding Digital Behavior

I have researched how people use and experience digital products and services across many customer contexts. I look beyond obvious friction: how digital feels in real life, where people hesitate, lose trust or feel overloaded. I use behavioral insights and techniques to make experiences clearer, more useful and more human when it matters.



User Engagement Framework: A framework for how people start, adopt, repeat, return to and expand use of a digital service. It maps value, onboarding, first use, non-use, drop-out, recovery and needed touchpoints.



Experience Context Model: A model that places digital use inside customer experience and real-life context. It links user behaviour with needs, touchpoints, timing, trust and friction beyond the screen.

What I master

● Design Thinking & Doing

Double Diamond process | Problem framing | Co-creation setup | Journey mapping | Validation | Stakeholder alignment | Multidisciplinary delivery

● Ideation & Concept Designs

Figma | Miro | Ideation | Concept flows | Wireframes | Prototypes | Service improvement | Service innovation | Platforms | Mobile & web apps

● Research & Testing

Qualitative & quantitative research | Market analysis | Behavioral audit | Customer & user profiling | Behavior change & habits | Contextual mapping

● Digital Design Principles

UX | UI | Usability | Accessibility | WCAG | Design systems | Interaction patterns | UX writing | Error prevention | Human Digital Design principles

● Data & Technology

System integrations | Data flows | Data capture | Form logic | API context | Tracking needs | User access | AI use cases | Privacy & security constraints

● Experimentation & Conversion

A/B testing | Email, website, forms, notifications, landing pages | Personalisation | New technology | Digital stress | Detect & resolve emotional and mental friction | Behavioral techniques

Beyond Service Design

When the team needs extra support, I can also contribute in three adjacent areas: user engagement, customer engagement and research.

User Engagement From first use to daily habit

Guiding users through first value experiences, feature adoption and recovery. Step-by-step guidance where needed.

Customer Engagement From contact to value

Building customer relationships through relevant communication, lifecycle journeys and value growth.

Research Insight for better decisions

Setting up continuous research within a team: the right methods, enriched with behavioral understanding.

Relevant projects (1/2)

 [Full project details](#)

Research & Concept Design

Proximus – Billing Service

Business & Service Designer · Belgium · 2024

Proximus needed to reduce late payments, reminders and softcut risk. I mapped the billing journey, analysed behavioral barriers and redesigned the service logic with clearer timeframes, nudged communication and two flows: monthly payment support and better habits.

Behavior research

System thinking

Prototype

Web

Email

App

7

Payment profiles

Multi

Channel approach

Full

Service redesign

ALDI – Web & Folder UX

Redesigned key website pages and the digital folder to improve findability, usability, SEO and adoption.

Benelux · 2021

Miss Mira – Behavior Research

Applied deeper behavior research to shape an early AI companion app with personas, interviews and priority cases.

Hungary · 2023

EF – Marketing Coach App

Turned research and best practices into a maturity model, guided app structure and development-ready concepts.

The Netherlands · 2018–2019

Thales – Event Digitalisation

Turned fragmented event execution into one digital event-to-lead flow with booking, QR check-in and sales follow-up.

Worldwide · 2019

DPG Media – Trial & Buy

Redesigned DPG Media's trial subscription flow with onboarding, data modelling, lifecycle emails and A/B testing.

Belgium · 2020

Maxis AI – Concierge App

Improved the WhatsApp concierge service through use-case research, better conversations and booking fixes.

Spain · 2023

Platform Design

Brenntag – B Connect Platform Adoption

Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant · Europe · 2019

Brenntag wanted customers to shift from person-led ordering and document requests to a new self-service portal. I analysed adoption resistance, reprioritised features and shaped a country-specific onboarding and engagement framework to help customers reach first successful use and return.

Design Thinking

User research

User adoption

Behavior Change

Web

Email

+25%

Activation Rate

+35%

Satisfaction

3

Country pilot

Amadeus – Customer Portal

Shaped Amadeus' customer portal for support tickets, product updates, user feedback, beta access and SaaS usage.

Benelux · 2019

Telenet – Mobile Platform

Defined the first scope, requirements and cost estimate for a mobile self-service portal based on customer research.

Belgium · 2019

Reynaers – Pro Portal

Defined portal requirements for professionals, turning research into scope, functional analysis and dev input.

Belgium · 2021

Samsung – MySamsung

Shaped MySamsung onboarding and engagement, helping users register, use product support and join communities.

Europe · 2014

TomTom – Portal Activation

Improved registration and onboarding by clarifying customer portal value, reducing friction and guiding first use.

The Netherlands · 2014

D'leteren – Dealer Platform

Built brand-specific dealer platforms, automating campaign sign-up, asset delivery and central-local support.

Belgium · 2012 – 2014

[Full project details →](#)

Relevant projects (2/2)

 [Full project details](#)

Onboarding & Adoption

SCIA — Smart Engineering

Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant · Europe · 2021

Built SCIA's Smart Engineering programme to attract, educate and onboard civil engineering SaaS users. Led persona research, buyer and user journey mapping, content strategy and demo-flow redesign, then shaped localized education flows to support stronger adoption.

Segmentation

Onboarding

Education Flows

User Adoption

- 35%

Demo drop-off

+40%

First-use completion

6

EU countries

Amadeus – Hotel Bookings

Increased Amadeus hotel bookings with agent research, booking education, reward mechanics and usage campaigns.

Benelux · 2009

Wolters Kluwer – Teleroute

Built always-on retention flows for Teleroute, using segmented updates, personalised notifications and usage triggers.

Europe · 2016

Shell – Loyalty App

Increased loyalty app usage with in-app messages, notifications, status emails and tips for fuel and shop visits.

Belgium · 2022

Proximus – Mobile Onboarding

Shaped Proximus' mobile onboarding with content mapping, static-to-dynamic emails and interest tracking.

Belgium · 2024

Philips – Alarm Fatigue

Shaped Philips' nursing alarm education flow for nurses and patients with content mapping, emails and landing pages.

Europe · 2019

Philips – Smart Cities

Built Philips' Smart Cities lead hub with persona-led content, welcome emails, profiling and lead capture.

Europe · 2016

Redesign & Optimisation

McLaren – Premium Digital Experience

Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant · Europe · 2017

Redesigned the digital customer experience for a premium automotive brand. I reshaped emails, landing pages, content and key communication moments, then extended the experience into driving-event booking and a mobile app with richer owner content.

UX Research

CX Strategy

Mobile App

Website

Email

Multi

Touchpoints

10

Countries

- 50%

Manual event work

ONVZ – Completion Boost

Applied behavior techniques to lift VSCAN completion, with guided help, instant results and lead generation.

The Netherlands · 2018

Samsung – Premium Products

Built Samsung's B2B lead engine, linking segmentation, gated content, Eloqua nurture flows and Salesforce routing.

France · 2019

Audi – MyNewAudi

Turned a high-bounce lead form into a guided car-buying experience with behavioral techniques and test-drive flow.

Belgium · 2019

DPG Media – Retention Growth

Built always-on retention and upsell flows with dynamic content, A/B testing and landing page optimisation.

Belgium · 2020

Beobank – Car Loan Simulator

Redesigned a car loan simulator through UX research and friction mapping. Reduced steps from 5 to 3 and mental friction by 70%.

Belgium · 2024

Wolters Kluwer – Test & Learn

Built a test culture across emails, landing pages, forms and paid media to improve digital performance.

Europe & US · 2015

[Full project details →](#)

From Research to Real-Life Use

"Digital solutions only work when they fit real-life use. I turn research, journeys and service logic into wireframes, prototypes and usable flows"



"Public services touch real moments in people's lives. I help reduce institutional friction by making digital flows clearer, more human and easier to use."

What makes me a strong fit

● Senior Hands-on

I think strategically, but also work hands-on with product, UX/UI, data and delivery, from feature scope to adoption and handover.

● Ownership

I take ownership quickly, clarify priorities, align stakeholders, and stay accountable for the work, the decisions and the handover.

● Contextual Research

I combine research, data and real-life context to understand needs, friction and behavior, then turn insights into concrete design actions.

● Agile Collaboration

I am used to agile collaboration: SAFe, Scrum and squad/tribe setups, design sprints, adapting fast to how teams work.

● Alignment & Stakeholders

I connect business, product, UX and delivery teams, align different needs and turn complexity into workable decisions.

● Team Enablement

+40 workshops and trainings. I help teams, product managers and stakeholders adopt better tools, processes and ways of working.



"I am used to corporate and institutional settings with multiple stakeholders, formal processes, business rules and governance. I adapt quickly, respect how organisations work and help teams move forward with clarity."

● Technology

Proximus (BE)
Business & Service Designer (2024)
Telenet (BE)
Business & Service Designer (2019)
Thales (Worldwide)
Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant (2018–2019)
Philips (NL)
Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant (2017–2019)
Amadeus (WEMEA)
Innovation Manager (2011)
Samsung (EU)
Marketing Automation Consultant (2014)+
Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant (2016–2018)

● Finance

Beobank (BE)
UX Research Consultant (2025)
+ Marketing Automation Consultant (2012)
Rabobank (NL)
Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant (2016–2019)
ING (NL)
Customer Experience & Engagement Consultant (2018)
Euronext (BE)
Marketing Automation Consultant (2014)
Securex (BE)
Marketing Automation Consultant (2014)